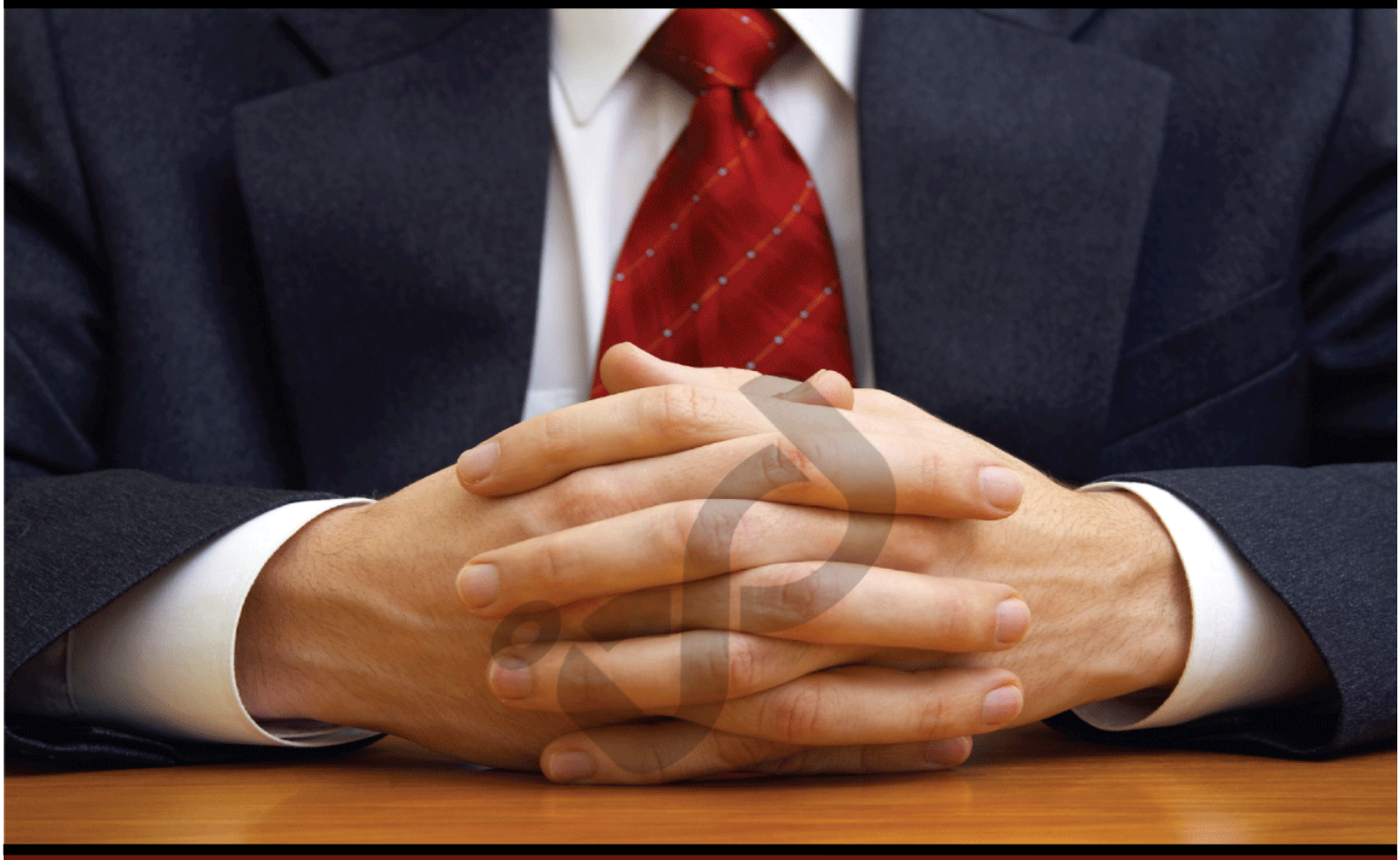
MOCK INTERVIEW HANDBOOK



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INTERVIEW SKILLS

THE PURPOSE OF AN INTERVIEW

An interview is a mutual exchange of information between an employer and you, as a candidate for a position. The primary objectives are to:

- Supplement resume information
- Show that you understand your strengths and weaknesses and have a sense of direction
- Enable the employer to evaluate your personality and attitudes in terms of the demands of the organization and the position
- Allow you to gain information about the organization and the job that is not available through other sources
- Give you and the employer an opportunity to discuss the desirability of further contact or an offer of employment

FIRST IMPRESSIONS

Your success or failure in an interview can depend on your appearance and the interviewer's first impression of you. Research indicates that, on average, an interviewer decides to hire in just 5½ minutes. If the first impression is not positive, it will be difficult to change the interviewer's mind during the rest of the interview.

Be punctual. Arrive ten minutes early to allow yourself time to collect your thoughts. Take the opportunity to observe the work environment. Keep your eyes and ears open.

Look professional—neat, clean, and well groomed. Select proper clothing for the type of organization interviewing you. If in doubt, be conservative. It is also advisable to keep fashion accessories to a minimum, to avoid wearing strong scents, and to turn off devices such as cell phones and electronic organizers.

Greet each person with respect and professionalism. When you shake hands, make eye contact and smile. Handshakes should be firm but not aggressive; try to match the grip of the interviewer. It is good etiquette to wait to sit down until the interviewer invites you to do so.

INTERVIEW CHECK LIST:

- Polished Resume
- Professional Attire
- Portfolio, Pen
- Positive Attitude

INTERVIEW PREPARATION

KNOW THE COMPANY/ORGANIZATION

You must be familiar with the position and the organization so that you can demonstrate your interest in and fit for the job. Refer to the research notes you made as you reviewed print and online materials, spoke with people about the position, and prepared your resume and cover letter.

A commonly asked interview question is: "What do you know about our company?" If you are unable to answer this question effectively, employers will see this as a sign of disinterest.

ANSWERING INTERVIEW QUESTIONS

The next phase of the interview consists of the interviewer asking you questions to try to determine your fit. Having knowledge of potential questions helps you to prepare points to include in your answers. Think about why a question is being asked. What does the employer really want to know?

Behavior-based and situational/hypothetical questions are increasing in popularity because they are considered to be more valid predictors of on-the-job performance.

BEHAVIOR-BASED QUESTIONS

Behavior-based interviews are designed to elicit information about how you have performed in the past because past behavior is a good indicator of how you will function in the future. Interviewers develop their questions around the traits and skills they consider necessary for succeeding in a position or organization.

These questions usually begin with phrases such as:

- Tell me about a time...
- Describe a situation in which...
- Recall an instance when…
- Give me an example of…

Some applicants find the format of these questions difficult to understand and have trouble responding. However, if you have done your research and prepared for the interview, you will have work, academic, and life experiences ready to share. You can prepare for behavior-based questions by recalling specific actions that demonstrate your accomplishments, abilities, and fit for the position.

Be certain to tell the truth, get to the point, stay focused, turn negatives into positives, and be consistent with your responses.

COMMON BEHAVIOR-BASED INTERVIEW THEMES INCLUDE:

- Working effectively under pressure
- Handling a difficult situation with a co-worker
- Applying good judgment and logic in solving a problem
- Thinking creatively
- Completing a project on time
- Persuading team members to do things your way
- Writing a report or proposal that was well received
- Anticipating potential problems and developing preventative

- Making an important decision with limited facts and information
- Making a quick decision during the absence of a supervisor
- Making an unpopular decision
- Adapting to a difficult situation
- Being tolerant of a different opinion
- Using your political savvy to promote a program or idea that you really believed in
- Dealing with an upset client or customer
- Delegating a project effectively
- Explaining complex information to a client, colleague, or peer
- Surmounting a major obstacle
- Prioritizing the elements of a complicated project

By analyzing the questions asked of you, you will discover further details about the position. Does the interviewer seem to be emphasizing certain skills, knowledge, personality traits, and attitudes? That insight can help you tailor your answers more easily to the employer's position.

ANSWERING BEHAVIOR-BASED QUESTIONS: W5 MODEL

The W5 model is a useful method for answering a behavior-based question. The answer should take approximately 90 seconds (the length of a typical attention span).

70 seconds - Identify the skill/knowledge/ability and give an example of how you applied or developed it by explaining:

- What, Who, When, Where, Why, and How
- What the successful outcome was

20 seconds - Re-state the skill and outline the benefits transferable to the interviewer's organization

For example, in response to the query "What experience do you have organizing projects?" you determine that the qualification being evaluated is organizational skills. Your statement could be, "I have developed excellent organizational skills by working on two major projects. The one I would like to tell you about ended successfully six months ago."

Every statement you make must be true! Don't lie or embellish. Ideally, the illustration you choose to confirm your statement should be a project that required similar competency to the typical project the prospective employer wants you to organize. If you do not have a similar experience to relate, try to choose a relevant story from your academic, extracurricular, or volunteer activities.

Choose words that will help the employer visualize you in the experience. Whenever possible, include positive feedback from supervisors, colleagues, professors, and others to reinforce your accomplishment.

CLASSIC QUESTIONS:

In addition to asking the other types of questions, many employers rely on a series of standard questions, and you should prepare for them:

- Tell me about yourself
- What are your short-term goals? What about in two and five years? How are you preparing to achieve them?
- What is your vision or mission statement?
- What do you think you will be looking for in the job following this position?
- Why do you feel you will be successful in this work?
- What other types of work are you looking for in addition to this role?
- What supervisory or leadership roles have you had?
- For you, what are some advantages and disadvantages of working in a team environment?
- What did you like/dislike about your last job?
- What motivates you to do a good job?
- What are your strengths/weaknesses?
- What kinds of problems do you handle best?
- How do you reduce stress and try to achieve balance in your life?
- How did you handle a request to do something contrary to your moral code or business ethics?
- Why did you apply to our organization and what do you know about us?
- What do you think are advantages/disadvantages of joining our organization?
- What is the most important thing you are looking for in an employer?
- Why should I hire you?

The next step is the one that most candidates forget. Tell the interviewer what specific benefits or competitive advantage you can bring to the position because of the experience you have just described. For example, "As part of the team, I would be able to coordinate...." Avoid generic statements such as "All organizations need people with leadership ability."

SITUATIONAL/HYPOTHETICAL QUESTIONS

An interviewer will use situational/hypothetical questions to establish how you would react to and handle real-life situations on the job. For situational/hypothetical questions, candidates must have a good understanding of the job and its requirements.

Here are some examples of this type of question:

- If you had met your project deadlines and your direct supervisor was unavailable, describe how you would remain busy.
- You are the manager of a small marketing team, and one individual is continually late for work and taking extended breaks. How would you approach the issue?
- During construction, a contractor unexpectedly finds a very large object in one of the trenches where he is about to dig. He requests that you tell him how to proceed. How would you deal with this situation?
- You plan a workshop to teach newcomers to the country how to use word processing software. Unfortunately, only four people have registered and you are required to have a class of ten. It is five days before the class is scheduled to begin. What do you do?
- You have a conflict with someone who is senior to you and is not your supervisor. Describe how you would handle it.

ANSWERING CLASSIC QUESTIONS- PAWS MODEL

The PAWS model is a useful method for answering classic questions such as "Tell me about yourself." The answer should take approximately 90 seconds (the length of a typical attention span).

When an employer asks this question, the employer is looking for those aspects of your life that are relevant to the job, such as how you became interested in the field, related experience, and courses taken.

The "PAWS" acronym stands for Profile, Academic, Work, and Skills. Include all or as many of the four (in any order) to reinforce your fit for the job. As with any interview response, limit your answer to a maximum of ninety seconds.

Here are some examples of what to discuss in each of the four areas: